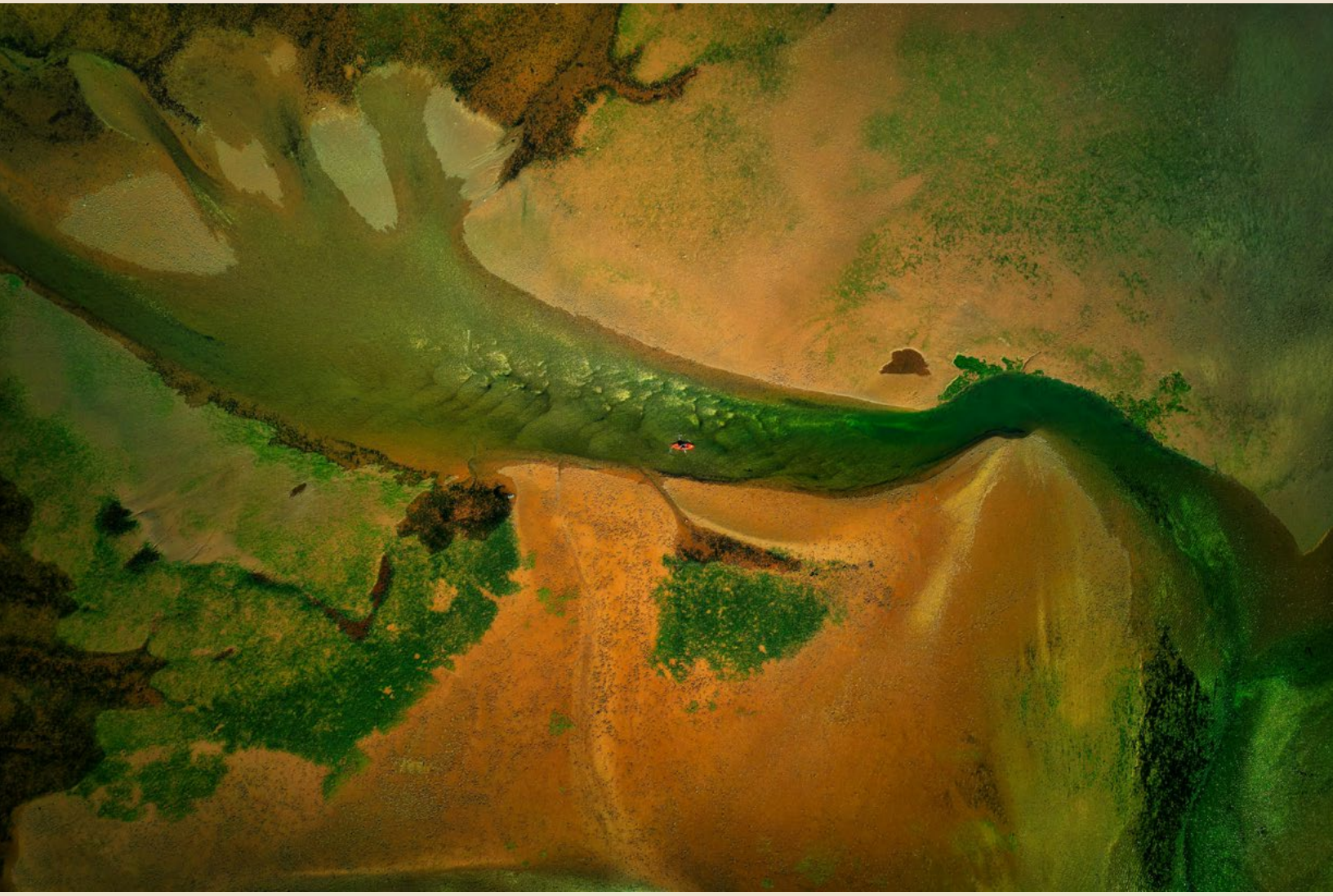
Estuary Leader Training Manual



Estuary exists to foster open, welcoming communities which are dedicated to honest and respectful dialogue.

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What is Estuary?

Estuary is a type of discussion group which is open to anyone who seeks to deeply explore topics with others. The group is a hospitable, welcoming space in which participants practice listening well, articulating their thoughts, and engaging in respectful, authentic dialogue.

Why participate in an Estuary?

Estuary has the power to build deep connections among different people across ideological, philosophical, cultural, and all demographic lines. It encourages participants not only to speak, but also to listen. In the give and take of the conversation, participants practice active listening, building empathy and understanding, paving the way to build a community which is relationally engaged both within the context of the conversations, but also in the world.

Here's where You Come in

So you want to be an Estuary leader? Great! This manual will take you through what makes an Estuary Group, how to run an Estuary Group, and how to start an Estuary Group. While it isn't necessary, we encourage you to practice what is outlined here on an ELSNet field call, where Estuary leaders from around the world tune in to troubleshoot, share ideas, and practice the Protocol. We hope these tools will help you to launch your own group and continue spreading the greatness of Estuary!

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The Role of an Estuary Group Leader

The key to leading an Estuary lies in three components:

1. Hosting
2. Facilitating
3. Modeling

Hosting

Hospitality helps inform how an experience is received. We all know the famous Maya Angelou quote, "I've learned that people will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them feel." Being a good host helps put people at ease and feel more comfortable to return or bring friends. Small actions go a long way. Here are a few examples of how to be a good host:

If you serve food, ask participants about their dietary restrictions and always have a food option for a person's allergies (eg. offering a gluten free option for anyone who may have Celiac's Disease)

If you host the group in your home, make sure your space is tidy and the bathroom is clean

Greet every person when they come in and always act first to introduce yourself to someone you do not know

Facilitating

Facilitating a discussion and modeling behavior are closely related. The way to frame facilitation is through the lens of responsibility: you are responsible for the conversation. That means you are the time keeper, you keep the conversation on track where needed, and mediate between people or ideas. Practically speaking, you explain and oversee the Protocol and start and end the discussion.

Examples of Facilitating the group:

Officially start the session: "Ok, well, I want to be respectful of everyone's time, so let's go ahead and get started. Welcome! Why don't we start by introducing ourselves since we have two newcomers this week..."

If you are hearing two people talk past each other in the group: "If I'm hearing you correctly, Jane, you are saying (summary) right? So Mike, I think you're understanding her to say (summary) when what she's really pointing to is..."

Play the devil's advocate! Even defending an opinion you don't share. If the group has a majority leaning heavily on one side of an argument, fill in the other side of the argument with its strongest or clearest points.

Officially end the session: "We have a few more minutes before we need to wrap up, so if anyone has a last thought to share before we go, please do." Or: "With that, I want to be respectful of your time, so we'll end here. Thanks for an engaging discussion! If you want more snacks, please help yourself!"

Modeling

In any group discussion, the facilitator sets the tone for conversation. This means that if you want your group to be vulnerable, you must be vulnerable. If you want the group to ask questions, you must ask questions. If you want the group to listen well, you must listen well. This begins at the first meeting and carries on through subsequent meetings. Practically speaking, this means that on the first meeting after you explain the Protocol, you go first to model the Protocol in action. After the group gets the hang of it, you will not have to go first and can launch with another participant.

Examples of ways to Model the habits of the group:

Show you are listening well: "That's an interesting thought. If I understand you correctly [Name], do you mean that (say back a summation of what they said)? Ok, well that prompts me to think..."

Model vulnerability by sharing a personal experience related to the topic at hand

Model listening well by not commanding the discussion. Try to listen more than you speak.

How to Run an Estuary Group

Here is where we outline the Protocol which is what makes Estuary different from other discussion groups. The beauty of the Protocol is that it requires zero preparation (no homework for participants to complete ahead of time!) and it gives everyone space to have a say in what the group will discuss.

The Protocol

The Protocol is simply the beginning structure of the group. With the Protocol, all Estuary groups start the same way.

Round 1

The first round is for each participant to introduce themselves. You can begin by sharing: Name, how you heard about Estuary and why you are interested in Estuary. You don't have to do the same extra components each week, but until you have a core group of regular attenders who remember each other's names, you should start each meeting with introductions.

Round 2

In the next round, you go in the same order and either share a topic for the evening or pass. The topic can be under the heading of one of four categories listed below. This is the suggested order to introduce the categories, however, you may introduce them in any order which makes sense for your context:

1) Intellectually
This can be a podcast you've listened to, a book you have read, a movie you've seen, or an article you've read which was thought provoking.

2) Culturally/Contextually
World events, something happening locally in your area, politics, etc

3) Personally
This can be something you are going through right now, a life change like moving, having a baby, getting married, getting divorced, breaking up, starting a new job, death of a loved one etc. While the group may not discuss this particular thing, it is nice to know what is happening in one another's lives so we can celebrate or empathize with one another.

4) Estuarily
This is relating to Estuary itself - what you're thinking of the group, the protocol, or any thoughts you may have regarding issues at large with Estuary

Round 3

Continuing in the same order, each participant votes on the topic they most wish to discuss. No passes this time!

Launch!

As the facilitator, you listen to the votes on what to discuss and officially 'launch' the discussion based on the consensus you hear. At this point, the discussion goes natural where people can share as they wish, no longer going around the circle.

Practice, practice, practice!

Now that you have an idea of what the Protocol is and how to employ it, you should practice it with other people! A great place to do so is on ELSNet, a place for Estuary leaders around the world to meet, practice Estuary discussions, and troubleshoot all things relating to starting and maintaining an Estuary Group. Sign up for an ELSNet session on our website: www.estuaryhub.com

How to Start an Estuary Group

While you wait for an ELSNet session, you may be brainstorming ways to start your own Estuary Group. Based on the collective experiences of many Estuary leaders, here are a few suggestions and things to keep in mind.

Co-hosting vs. Hosting on Your Own

There are plenty of Estuary Groups run by one group leader and plenty of Estuary Groups run by co-leaders. There are pros and cons to each scenario, but especially if this is your first Estuary Group or your first foray into leading any sort of group, we highly recommend finding a Co-Host. With two people running the group, there is back-up if someone gets sick, a family emergency comes up, or when you go on vacation, ie. when life happens. A co-host is also a great sounding board and a second pair of eyes and ears to help process, brainstorm, and reflect. It can also make for a more balanced dynamic in the group when two people share in the Hosting/Facilitating/Modeling mindset. Most of all, it is really great to have a friend in your corner too, so you can both lean on each other and share the burdens of leading a group.

How to Find Interested People to Attend Your Group

While every group is different, we have found that there are 2 primary ways most groups get started:

1) Personal Invitation/Word of Mouth
2) App Listings (Meetup.com or Estuary Hub)

When trying to start any kind of group, by far the most difficult part is garnering interest. It is hard, people are busy, and seemingly now more than ever, people have a hard time committing to social engagements. However, do not despair! Once people try Estuary, they usually love it. Many participants say that the group is life-giving, refreshing, and so beneficial for them. Many people also say that everyone should try Estuary because we all crave deep connection. We know there is a huge need for the type of space Estuary provides for all people.

That being said, it can take some time before an Estuary Group gets off the ground. We want you to see this as an encouragement - a group can take anywhere from 1-5 years to start. Even longer! So don't get discouraged in your efforts to get one going. Two big tips are: listen well to the people around you and be patient.

Personal Invitation

When thinking about who to invite to an Estuary Group, we can already get bogged down. Remember the tips above: listen and be patient. Many times when we look to start a group, we can make the process over complicated. If you want to start a group, instead of immediately rushing out to find people who would be interested, take some time to consider the people you see on a regular basis. Think about where you are already.

Home: think of your home and your neighborhood. Who are your neighbors? Who do you see regularly? Are there people you already see daily or weekly? If you already greet someone regularly or even know their name and some surface level information about them, they may be open to an invitation.

Neighborhood: think of the places you visit regularly like the grocery store, a coffee shop, the gym, etc. Are there people in any of these places with whom you have built a relationship, even if it's just a greeting?

Work: think of your place of work. If your work is in an office with colleagues, is there anyone at work you think would be interested in deep conversation?

Other people to consider: if you have children - other parents you know, people from other clubs or organizations you are involved with.

Again, the key here is to think of where you are already. It is so much easier to start there! Listen out in these spaces and open yourself to the possibility that someone you already know would really enjoy Estuary. If you have a particularly interesting or thought provoking exchange, you could ask: "Hey, do you like talking about this sort of thing? My friend and I are thinking of starting a discussion group and this is exactly what it's like! Would you be interested?"

Or if you have a positive rapport with someone but haven't had a deep exchange yet, you can point to the thing you have in common and offer Estuary as an easy thing: "So since our kids' baseball practice is two hours long, and we're all just sitting here waiting for them to finish up, I have an idea I'd like to float by you..."

Online Listings or Advertisements

Other Estuary Groups have had great success garnering interest through online platforms such as meetup.com. You can explore the digital listing platforms available in your area and try it out. This can be helpful because the participants who come to you this way will be seeking Estuary out based on their own interests. You are also always welcome to list your Estuary Group on the Estuary website in case people visiting the site are interested in attending a group in your area.

Where to Host an Estuary Meeting

For in-person Estuary Groups, there are two types of spaces to choose from: public spaces or a private living space. What you choose should ultimately come down to what is convenient and manageable. For people in a city, for example, apartments can be small or a communal space for roommates, so sometimes a public space makes more sense, especially if it offers food and drink. In other areas, public spaces may have inconvenient hours, or it just makes sense to host out of someone's home since the interested people all live close by.

Things to consider for a space: food and drink is very helpful to make people feel comfortable and because we all enjoy it! Noise levels are also important to consider as you will want to make sure people can hear each other when they speak. Space to sit comfortably and spread out, especially if your Estuary grows large enough to split into two groups.

For virtual Estuary Groups, the most popular platforms are Zoom and Streamyard. Something to consider with these is the cost of a subscription in order to host longer calls. Estuary may be able to offer financial assistance to those who qualify, however, as we are a non-profit, this is solely dependent upon available funds allotted for this use. If you are interested in applying for financial assistance, you can do so here on our website: www.estuaryhub.com

Meeting Rhythms and Maintaining Momentum

In order to maintain the momentum of your Estuary Group, you will want to decide on your meeting times and frequency. We recommend anything from every two weeks to once a month as a comfortable rhythm which will maintain the energy of the group without too much time between meetings. We also recommend meeting on the same day and time slot to facilitate scheduling. For example, you can have an Estuary that meets every other Monday at 7pm at someone's house, or the first Wednesday of every month at 12pm on Zoom. Whatever the rhythm is, try your best to maintain it to ensure consistency for participants. This is a part of facilitating a group in which it really helps to have a co-host to partner with. Maintaining the rhythm is much easier if you have a partner to keep it going if something comes up.

How to Create and Maintain a "Safe" Space and Positive Experience

By nature of what Estuary is, most people are respectful and make space for others. That being said, we are all human! Sometimes we commandeer the discussion, overstep, or speak without thinking. It's important to model the behavior you expect in the group. If you feel it's necessary, you can even go so far as to announce that what is said in the group, stays in the group. Apply conventional wisdom for how to be kind to others. You can empathize when someone shares something personal which is very hard. You can hold space for people as they express their thoughts, showing empathy by smiling and nodding. Again, good listening skills go a long way to build an environment in which we empathize with one another.

For virtual online groups, we discourage recording the Estuary discussion. Recording usually leads to people being self-conscious of the fact that whatever they say will be "out there" so to speak and leads to self-censorship. Since the point of Estuary is to be able to share freely and build vulnerability, self-censorship is the opposite of what we are trying to build.

Last thing to Consider for the "Where"

There are pros and cons for both hosting a group in person and online. Of the two, we recommend in person as the ideal. Sharing a physical space with others allows for more fluid discussion and facilitates all the subconscious parts of participating in a conversation. That being said, if in person just isn't possible, online groups are also very good and certainly much better than nothing! We discourage a hybrid model as incorporating people on the screen into the in person experience of a discussion is incredibly difficult.

